



**ANNUAL
REPORT
2023**
Bangladesh





**WE ARE AN NGO
THAT EDUCATES,
PROTECTS AND
EMPOWERS CHILDREN**



Alema Akter
Student
Bridge school
Child labour elimination project
Educo Bangladesh

" I really enjoy school! In addition to reading and numeracy, we learn to sing, dance, and recite poetry! And guess what? We even play games, which I never imagined I could do as a girl. There are plenty of toys and exciting things to play with, and we even get a tiffin! The school feels like a safe space where I can be myself and have the most fun ever!"

25 YEARS CELEBRATION



Last year, we celebrated the **25th anniversary** of our journey in **Bangladesh**. Over the past quarter-century, we have remained devoted to our mission to transform lives through education, protection, and empowerment.

Our untiring dedication has focused on delivering high-quality education, empowering children, adolescents, and youth, and fostering persistent change for children and their families throughout Bangladesh.

CEO's foreword

The 2023 Annual Report reflects Educo Bangladesh's commitment and efforts to positively transform the lives of children and adolescents through education, protection, and empowerment.

Over the past year, we have continued to work closely with the government, communities, and families to develop programmes that aim to provide quality education, empower children and communities, and promote positive and lasting social change using a rights-based approach. Our work has been focused on laying a solid base for change.

Early Childhood Care and Education and Preschool Education programmes provide the foundation for this transformation. We have also launched initiatives to promote quality education and address persistent challenges such as child labour, school dropout rates, and limited access to education. We are committed to continuing to work to address these challenges comprehensively.

Child protection continues to be a cornerstone of our programmes. Our goal is to ensure that children and adolescents in Bangladesh thrive in safe and nurturing environments. We strive to promote a protective environment for them, improving child protection systems at national and local levels and sustainably reducing the presence of children and adolescents in the worst forms of child labour and exploitation. We also actively work to reduce gender-based violence against children and adolescents, challenging social norms that perpetuate gender inequality and tolerate violence as a form of discipline.

In this context, I would like to highlight the courageous example of some girls from the Rajshahi district who defied gender stereotypes by actively participating in school football competitions and win! These young women are an excellent example of the positive impact our programmes can have on children's lives, empowering them to overcome barriers and reach their full potential.

Our mission is to empower children, adolescents, and young people to drive social change, equipping them with the tools to actively participate in society and become agents of transformation. We strongly believe in the power of youth to generate positive and sustainable change in their communities, and we work tirelessly to strengthen their agency and voice. In the economic area, we have promoted actions that seek to provide young people with decent employment opportunities. We believe in their entrepreneurial potential and strive to support them in creating sustainable livelihoods.

In addition, over the past year, we have continued to provide a humanitarian response in the Cox Bazar refugee camp, prioritising child protection, gender-based violence prevention, and anti-discrimination. We recognise the importance of adapting to emerging humanitarian challenges and are committed to supporting those most in need in times of crisis.

Lastly, we have strengthened our focus on disaster risk reduction and climate change adaptation. We work closely with adolescents and young people to improve their resilience and coping capacity in the face of climate variability and environmental risks,

engaging them as active agents in climate change management and disaster risk reduction. Without a doubt, Educo Bangladesh's experience in disaster risk reduction and climate change adaptation serves as a guide for the NGO's head office and other countries.

The year 2023 has been a year of challenges and achievements for Educo Bangladesh. We are deeply grateful for the continued support and collaboration of all our supporters and partners in this journey towards a more just and equitable present and future for all children and adolescents in Bangladesh.



Pilar Orenes
Executive Director
Educo

Pilar Orenes

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Pilar Orenes". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style and is positioned below a horizontal line.

Letter from the Country Director

In 2023, as we reflect on our illustrious 25-year journey, we are filled with pride and gratitude. Despite the unprecedented challenges of climate crisis, natural disaster, economic crisis, lack of quality education and health services, Educo remained persistent in its commitment to ensuring child rights and well-being in Bangladesh to build a brighter future. Throughout the year, we continued implementing various programmes and initiatives to address the multiple barriers children, adolescents and youth face in accessing their rights, even in an emergency. From advocating for policy changes to providing direct support to communities, our efforts were guided by our commitment to making a lasting impact on the lives of our children and their families.

In our core belief, we embody that education is not only a fundamental right, but also a powerful tool for empowerment and social change, and our work reflects on exemplifying this notion at every step. One of the highlights of 2023 was the successful retention of our intervention in 10 districts we were working in and reached 91, 447 children and young people including Rohingya communities. By collaborating closely with local partners and stakeholders, we worked at 140 ECD centres, 276 schools and 233 communities, ultimately enhancing the well-being and educational outcomes of thousands of children and adolescents across Bangladesh.

We work for children so they can avail themselves of their rights, get quality education, and become conscious human beings who know and apply their social responsibilities. Our life skills sessions created a blessing potion to youth's lives; they can face day-to-day challenges with informed decision-making. We were digging deep to boost adolescents and youth energy, making 376 adolescents and youth ambassadors who facilitated peer education of life skills training to 3,703 youth participants, significantly impacting their personal and social lives.

Sometimes, we unconsciously hold ourselves back, not realising the vast potential we possess. On top of that, our gender division of labour limits our sky, especially girl children still facing tremendous discrimination in our society, though we have progressed in many ways compared to our past. In remote Bangladesh, adolescent girls are not allowed to play outdoors, besides they still confront huge discrimination compare to their counterpart. At Educo, we believe sports are life-changing tools that can dismantle and challenge gender discrimination. One of our key achievements this year is to make 5,000 sport persons. Many of them are establishing their career in regional and national level.

We were digging deep to boost our capacity. At the same time, we focused on building the capacity of local partners and stakeholders, equipping them with the skills and resources needed to support the holistic development of children, adolescents, and youth. Through teacher training workshops, parenting sessions, and community engagement activities, we fostered a culture of learning and collaboration that will continue to benefit children for years.

Our commitment is to build a more sustainable and equitable society, in this connection, we are making direct and indirect contributions to Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). We uphold the principles of 'Leaving No One Behind and Reaching the Furthest Behind First' and working to make positive changes in the lives of children adolescents and youth.

We sincerely appreciate the ongoing support and collaboration of our well-wishers and partners as we strive towards a more equal world for children and adolescents.



Abdul Hamid
Country Director
Educo Bangladesh

Abdul Hamid

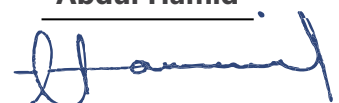
A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read 'Hamid', written over a horizontal line.

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VISION, MISSION, VALUES



Vision

A world where all girls and boys have access to educational environments and fully enjoy their rights and a dignified life.



Mission

We work with children and their environment to promote just and equitable societies that guarantee their rights and well-being.



Values

Social commitment: We strive for the common good, the defence of human dignity, working together to build relationships based on fairness and solidarity between peoples, individuals and cultures.

Equity: Our actions aim to achieve greater justice in social arrangements and to promote people's ability to enjoy their freedom.

Respect: We recognise and defend the richness of human diversity as an essential value for social cohesion, peace and respect for the dignity of all people.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

Non-discrimination: Our work is built upon the belief that all children should have the opportunity to fulfil their rights, irrespective of their or their families' national, ethnic or social origin, language, religion, political opinion, economic position, disability or any other status.

Participation: All our actions guarantee and promote the right to participation of children and those who support them, in pursuit of full citizenship. We also foster a participatory culture within our organization.

Transparency: We base our work on honesty, responsibility and maximum access to information regarding the management of resources and the impact of our actions, in pursuit of the highest levels of social and economic accountability.

Dynamic spirit: We have the capacity to adapt and be creative in our response, seeking innovation and quality in our action.



BUILDING A BETTER WORLD FOR CHILDREN



We work to build a world where all children fully enjoy their rights and lead a dignified life. At Educo we believe that education is the most powerful tool to change the world. Education not only as a body of academic knowledge, but it is something much more powerful: it moves the world and transforms it into the place where children deserve to live.

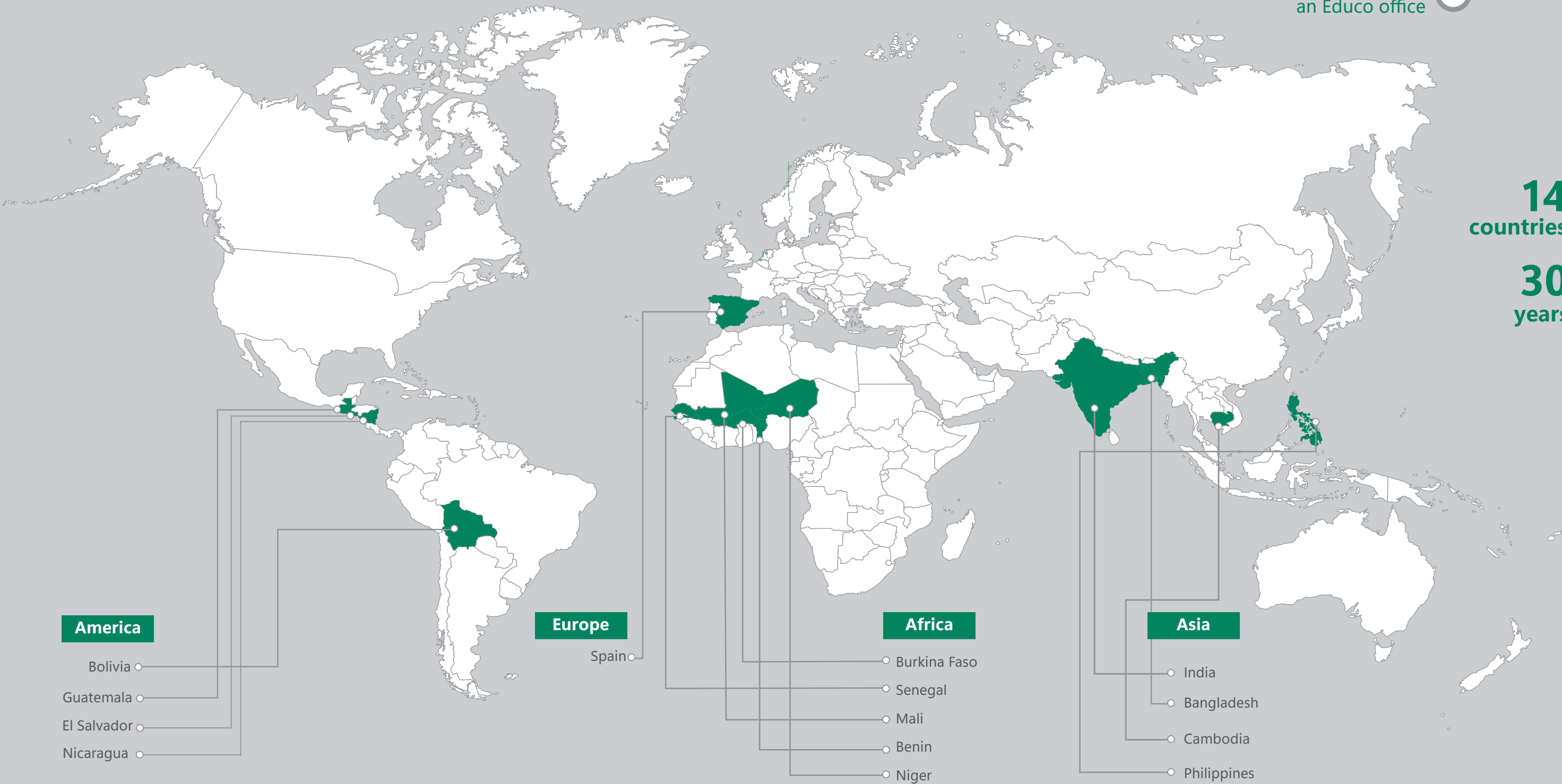
EDUCO ACROSS THE GLOBE

We are a global development and humanitarian NGO headquartered in Barcelona, Spain. For more than 30 years, we have worked in 14 countries to promote the well-being and rights of children, especially the right to receive a quality education.

Countries with an Educo office 

14 countries

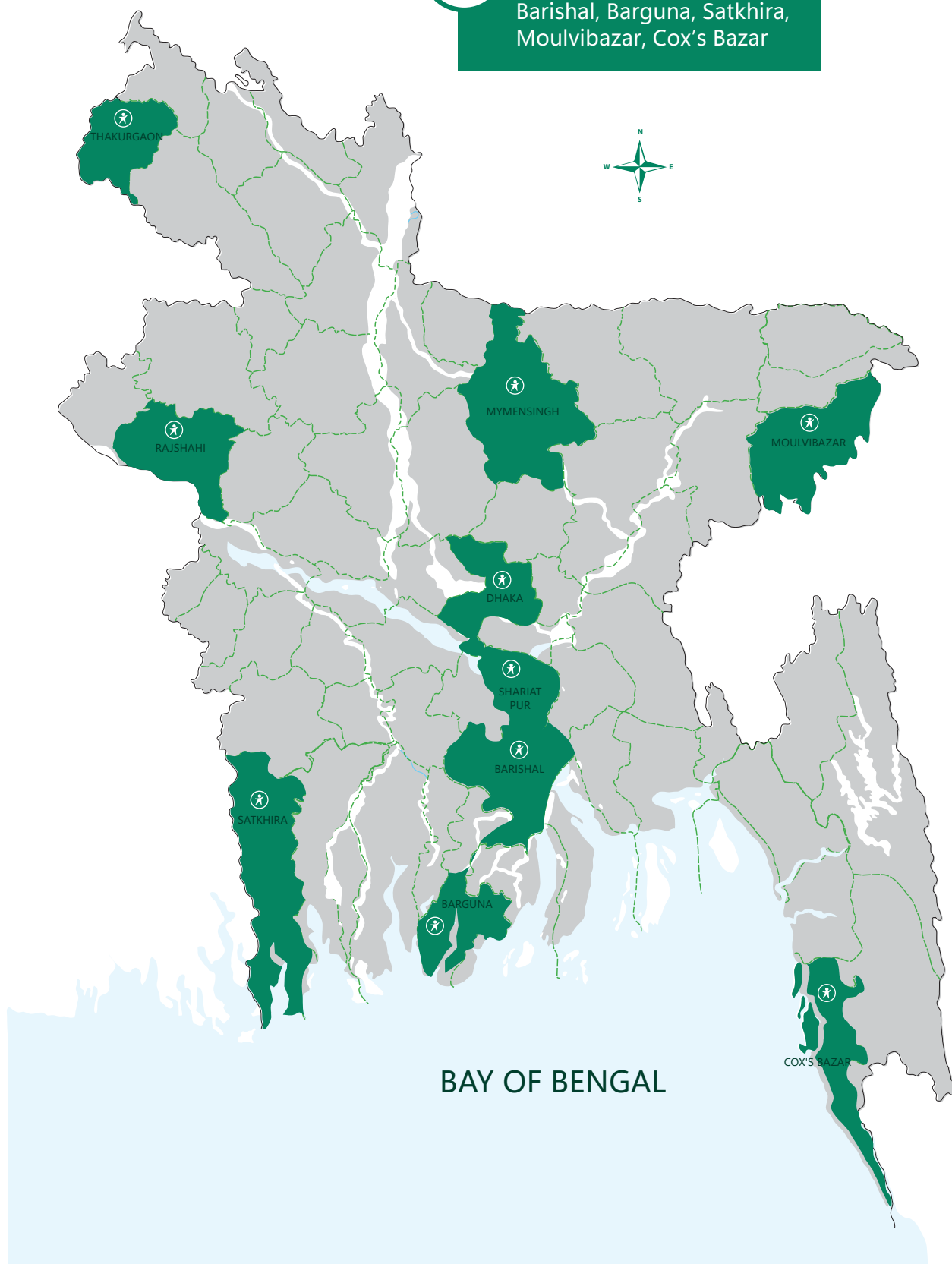
30 years



EDUCO BANGLADESH INTERVENTION AREAS



Rajshahi, Takurgaon, Dhaka,
Mymensingh, Shariatpur,
Barishal, Barguna, Satkhira,
Moulvibazar, Cox's Bazar



2023

At A Glance: In Bangladesh



Children and young people

91,447



Adults

55,479



Boys

40,307



Girls

51,138



Women

31,659



Men

23,816



Districts

10



Partners

15



Primary schools

226



Secondary schools

50



ECD centres

140



Day care centres

11



Communities

233



Projects

22



Adolescents and youth clubs

308



Community-based child
protection committees

241

CONTRIBUTION TO SDGs

With a commitment to building a more **sustainable and equitable society**, Educo Bangladesh is making direct and indirect contributions to various SDGs. The organisation's impactful, enduring programmes have helped achieve SDGs' targets and brought about significant positive changes in the **lives of children and vulnerable communities**, instilling a sense of hope and optimism for a brighter future.

Aligned with the principles of '**Leaving No One Behind and Reaching the Furthest Behind First**,' Educo aspires to educate children, empower girls and women, improve working conditions, and enhance accessibility to essential human services alongside awareness initiatives. Despite all the hurdles, Educo Bangladesh has made substantial contributions to the SDGs by emphasising inclusive and equitable quality education, early childhood development and care, pre-primary education, skills development and gender equality. These efforts have effectively addressed disparities and discrimination in fundamental human rights and opportunities, underscoring Educo's commitment to sustainable development.





STRATEGIC PLAN REVIEW

Global Impact Framework 2020–2030



Global Programmatic Framework 2021–2025



Country Programmatic Framework 2021–2025



Safe, equitable and quality education



Protection against violence and exploitation



Empower and agency for social change



Country Organisational
Development Plan 2021–2023

EDUCATION

Educo Bangladesh's comprehensive programme approach, spanning from early childhood development to primary education, served as evidence of Educo Bangladesh's dedication to promoting safe and equitable quality education for hard-to-reach children and adolescents. Numerous success stories over the years recognised the profound impact of education to shaping the lives of the underprivileged in ways that resonate far beyond the classroom.





Early childhood care

In 2023, Educo Bangladesh prioritised early childhood care & education (ECCE) and pre-primary education. The organisation underscored the crucial role of early childhood education in laying the foundation for lifelong learning by remaining committed to its vision of ensuring access to a holistic early childhood experience for a brighter future.

- **140 ECD centres** worked to help the young children to develop their cognitive development
- Established **11 day care centres** and supported 318 children that eased the difficulties of working mother who don't have anyone to take care of their children
- **1,557 young children enjoyed early learning opportunities** that fostered their school readiness skills
- Supported **4,728 children of pre-primary grade with packages of play and pedagogy materials** which enhanced their learning skills besides providing them happiness



Amir's blossomed into a confident learner

Amir Hossain, a 4-year-old, lives with his family in the Baikkabeel wetland area of Sreemangal, Moulvibazar. His father, the family's sole breadwinner, works as a fisherman. However, his job is seasonal, and he often faces limited opportunities to catch fish for around four months during the dry season. This period of financial strain often necessitates borrowing and assistance to sustain the family, adding to the challenges they face. Amir's mother, in addition to caring for the children, cultivates vegetables in their backyard. However, more is needed for their home expenses.

Since age two, Amir has displayed concerning behaviour marked by stubbornness, shyness, and difficulty in social interactions and speech development. For these reasons, his parents enrolled him in the Baruna Hazipur ECD centre in 2022, facilitated by MSED and funded by ChildFund Korea through Educo Bangladesh.

Initially, Amir struggled to adapt to the centre, exhibiting resistance and aggression towards peers and facilitators.



Recognising his needs, the ECD facilitator provided extra care and encouragement, advising his parents to engage him in quality time at home.

Over time, Amir's positive changes became evident. With support and guidance from the ECD facilitator and his parents, he became a confident and eager learner. Now, he actively participates in activities, communicates effectively, and demonstrates various skills such as reciting rhymes, drawing, and identifying objects.

Amir, filled with hope, expressed,

// I love going to school and aspire to become a police officer in the future //

Educo Bangladesh addressed the issue of poor learning outcomes by implementing initiatives to support quality education. Inadequate ECCE opportunities, Child labour, dropping out, and limited access to education remained a significant concern. Educo Bangladesh strived to bridge the learning gap by engaging with dropouts and deprived students through community-based interactive learning sessions. These sessions focused on Bangla and Math by creating a joyful, play-based environment.

- **132 primary schools** reached to enhance quality education
- **23,108 children had access to quality primary education** with pedagogical materials for unlocking their potential
- **9,527 children received remedial support** in basic Bangla and Mathematics, significantly improving their proficiency and fostering a regular participation in school activities
- **13,041 children, adolescents, parents, teachers and other community people** were sensitised on fire incidents, earthquakes and death by drowning
- Established **32 libraries in 32 GPS, including 6 model libraries** to enhance the reading skills of children
- Hand washing facilities were set up in **132 centres, and 26 shallow tube wells and 30 deep tube wells** were installed at GPS and community levels to promote hygiene practices and clean water consumption

Quality education





Over the past year, Maria Akter Mahi's academic performance in fourth grade has been on a downward spiral. This can be attributed to a lack of familial support and guidance, which has left her feeling adrift. In class, she appears disengaged and lacking energy, particularly struggling with Bangla reading, writing, and mathematics. Her irregular attendance has created a significant gap in her education, further exacerbated by financial strain. Her father's neglect of familial responsibilities has left her mother, a garment worker, to bear the burden alone. Maria, feeling abandoned due to her parents' separation, now resides with her grandparents, who are unable to provide the academic support and concern she needs.

Recognising Maria's difficulty, her head teacher suggested enrolment in the Community-based Learning Centre (CBLC) in Vandara, Thakurgaon. Maria seized this opportunity eagerly, attending the centre regularly and receiving invaluable support.

With the assistance of CBLC, her academic performance improved steadily, allowing her to overcome her previous setbacks.

// I want to be a teacher and will empower underprivileged children to shape their futures positively. //

Witnessing Maria's positive shift, her grandparents expressed joy and satisfaction, by attending a parents' meeting at the CBLC centre. Maria's journey highlights the impact of Educo's CBLC programme, which not only enhances academic performance but also nurtures aspirations in children. Through quality education and support, CBLC enables children like Maria to dream ambitiously and pursue brighter futures, instilling a sense of hope in their lives.

PROTECTION

Educo Bangladesh prioritises protection as a cornerstone of its programmes, aimed at ensuring that children and adolescents in Bangladesh thrive in safe and nurturing environments. Our overarching aim is to foster a protective environment for them, focusing on enhancing the national and local level child protection systems. Besides, we directed efforts towards the sustainable reduction of children and adolescents involved in the worst forms of child labour and exploitation. Moreover, we worked to diminish gender-based violence against children and adolescents.





Strengthening child protection system

Educo Bangladesh promotes a protective environment for children and adolescents, especially their family and community environment, as this is their first circle of bonding and attachment. At the community level, we acted to strengthen the community-based child protection system for preventing violence against children with the support of local-level legal duty bearers. Besides, we formed and built the capacity of the community-based child protection committee (CBCPC) so that it became an active actor in preventing violence against children in the community.

- **162 CBCPC developed** an annual action plan to protect children of their communities from any kind of abuse and violence
- **14,719 children**, parents and other stakeholders raised awareness of children's rights to **protection from violence**
- **29 child marriages were stopped by engaging guardians**, local government, law enforcement agencies and relevant stakeholders



Synthia's astounding battle to conquer child marriage

// I used to think that if I could change myself, I could also change others, and now I'm more courageous to transform my own life, //



Residing in an underprivileged area, Synthia witnessed the neglect of education, particularly for girls in her community. When her parents decided to marry her off at seventeen, Synthia refused to accept their decision. She disclosed this matter to her friends at the club and asked for help. Without any delay, they reached out to Nari Maitree for assistance. Encouraged by the support of her friends, Synthia found strength to resist the forced marriage.

In collaboration with Educo, Nari Maitree established the Adolescent and Youth Club (AYC) in Kadamtali and the Community-based Child Protection Committee (CBCPC). Synthia is an active member of the Kadamtali CBCPC,

established by Nari Maitree, and participates in various trainings to enhance her life skills, motivation, and technical proficiency.

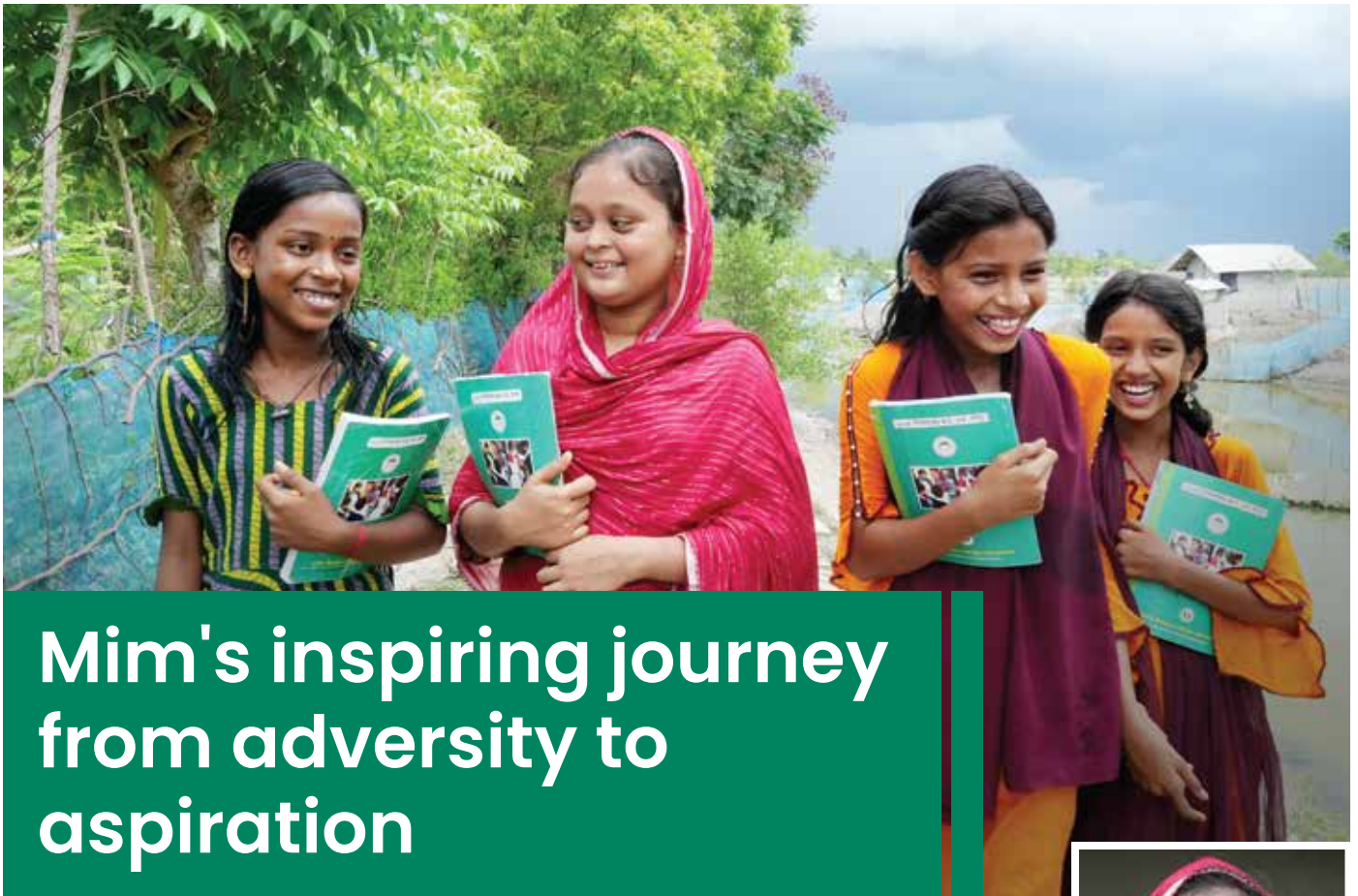
Through her involvement in the Child Protection Committee, Synthia gained awareness about child protection, child rights, the importance of girls' education, child policy, the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC), and the consequences of child marriage. These learnings bolstered her leadership skills, leading her to advocate for child protection within the community. These skills lead her to negotiate with her family to avert her own marriage, enabling her to pursue her education.

Educo Bangladesh takes proactive measures to remove children involved in the worst forms of child labour from selected informal sectors. We facilitate access to these children in general, technical, and vocational education, followed by job placement in dignified employment opportunities. Additionally, we actively work to reduce various forms of exploitation experienced by child labourers. Moreover, we collaborate with employers' associations, networks, alliances, and government authorities to drive sustainable change in the lives of children engaged in labour and those at risk of exploitation.

- **148 students had mainstreamed** in different educational institutions, out of 1400 enrolled students
- **75 children received vocational training** in various trades; among them, **40 are engaged** in decent jobs and started their careers as entrepreneur
- **27 teachers demonstrated** joyful learning sessions
- **1280 parents received** different motivational and awareness-raising sessions on child rights, child protection, child labour issues and the importance of education
- **403 children had withdrawn** from the hazardous child labour

Child labour elimination





Mim's inspiring journey from adversity to aspiration

// I dream of becoming a teacher while continuing my tailoring work. //



Mim resides with her family in Satkhira District. Her father's livelihood is sustained by catching fish and crabs in the Sundarbans, while her mother contributes by working in others' houses.

In 2020, Mim's education stopped due to the COVID-19 pandemic when she was in class seven. Mim and her mother worked in other households to contribute to the family income. However, her efforts were hindered by diabetes, a condition that brought both financial strain and emotional distress to Mim and her family. Fearing societal stigma, they concealed her health issues, especially given the prevailing expectation of early marriage for girls.

However, in 2021, Mim enrolled in Bridge School, which was initiated by Uttaran and funded by Educo Bangladesh. Enrolling in the bridge school, Mim found solace in regular education and completed a three-month tailoring training course in 2022.

The training strengthened her and opened new possibilities for her.

Recognising the financial strain on her family, Mim was determined to contribute. Despite financial constraints, her father acquired an old sewing machine for her. Starting with small orders for wages, Mim gradually saved money. This economic stability enabled her to resume her education in class eight at Secondary School. However, the challenges persisted as the old sewing machine posed hurdles to her work. In a promising turn, Uttaran, with the help of another project, provided Mim a new sewing machine, significantly boosting her working speed.

She acknowledges that the tailoring training and sewing machine greatly impacted her life, preventing her dreams from fading away. Without them, she would have faced early marriage like.



Combat gender-based violence

At Educo, we are committed to challenging harmful social norms that perpetuate gender inequality and condone violence as a form of discipline. Our work spans various regions of the country, aiming to eradicate gender-based violence by engaging children, adolescents, and youth (CA&Y) as powerful agents of societal transformation.

- **135 ambassadors received gender equality training**, and they shared their learning with the **1,000 members of the clubs**
- **1,069 children, adolescents** and youth became sensitive to preventing gender-based violence
- **Raised awareness of young people** on menstrual hygiene and gender equality



Sraboni is a young leader in her community

Sraboni Khatun, a 10th-grade student from Rajshahi District, is a peer educator of karate techniques. Since 2021, she has been an active member of the Adolescent & Youth Club, established by Sachetan Society with support from Educo Bangladesh. Recognised for her leadership qualities, she was elected president of the Child Protection Committee.

The club arranged karate training for its girl members, which Sraboni eagerly participated in. The martial arts lessons were delivered in a secure environment, focusing on safety. Upon completing the training, Sraboni's confidence soared as she gained the skills to defend herself in challenging situations. Inspired by her progress, she aspired to empower other girls in her community by becoming a young trainer for her peers.



“ The most rewarding aspect of teaching martial arts techniques is seeing how it boosts confidence among my peers. One participant shared that she now feels equipped to handle situations that used to frighten her ”

Sraboni expressed

EMPOWERMENT

Our mission is to empower children, adolescents, and youth to drive social change by equipping them with the necessary tools to exercise their right to participate in society and become informed decision-makers. We strive to nurture youth ambassadors who advocate for building a more equitable world for all individuals.





Organisation and agency for social change

Our youth empowerment programmes are not just about providing opportunities, but also about fostering dialogue and advocacy. Through dialogue sessions with stakeholders and advocacy with local government, we engage girls, boys, young women, and men from marginalised and diverse backgrounds across cultures and faiths. This approach is grounded in local realities and is grassroots-driven. It focuses on strengthening youth agencies so their voice can be heard and valued for bringing sustainable change. For instance, our advocacy has led to more girls getting equal opportunities to play male-dominated sports, breaking gender stereotypes and social stigma.

- **300 Adolescent and Youth Clubs** developed and executed their annual plans for building a harmonious society
- **2,404 adolescents and youth gained knowledge** and skills to build community association which can lead a sustainable social change
- **2,500 saplings planted** by adolescents and young members to build a greener planet
- **2,550 KG of plastic** was collected for recycling purposes by youth members



Nupur is a symbol of determination to fight against all kinds of hardships



Fatema Akter Nupur, a 20-year-old young woman, began her education at the Former Educo Pathshala. Currently, she is a first-year Honours student at Economic Bangladesh University.

Residing in the underprivileged area of Mohammadpur, Nupur faces a limited learning environment where the education rate is alarmingly low, primarily due to poverty and ignorance. After completing primary school, her father initially decided to end her studies. However, Nupur's determination compelled him to reconsider. Supported by her mother and Educo Bangladesh, Nupur continued her education.

"I received school fees and comprehensive support from Educo until grade ten," Nupur shared. Despite this support, she encountered numerous obstacles on her educational journey. A significant challenge arose in grade nine when her grandmother arranged a marriage for her, convincing Nupur's mother as well. Faced with pressure to marry, Nupur courageously stood her ground, refusing to marry under any circumstances. Educo Bangladesh provided support throughout, offering financial assistance and educational

materials. Nupur also experienced various trainings, including life skills, sexual and reproductive health rights, public service information, and child protection.

Subsequently, she facilitated training for her friends and other children in the community. Her impactful social initiatives include preventing child marriages, advocating for girls' education, addressing sexual harassment alongside the community, and fostering an eco-friendly society through tree plantation. Nupur also volunteers to educate slow learners in the community free of charge.

Approximately 40-50 adolescents and young people, inspired by Nupur's efforts, are actively contributing to positive social change. Through her initiatives, Nupur is transforming societal conditions and her own life.

I aspire to be well-established and to stand against oppression in all its forms. Additionally, I dream of becoming an entrepreneur to create employment opportunities for more youths ,

Nupur expressed

Life skills education to bolster their agility and adaptability by practising teamwork and effective communication in their personal and social environment has been a significant part of teenagers' and young's fulfilled lives. They have demonstrated an amplified voice in making informed decisions, taking action, and getting moving on their dreams. Moreover, many have opted out of their respective educational field to pursue a career or embark on their own business, which exemplifies some of the outcomes of the life-skills education.

- **376 adolescents** and youth ambassadors enhanced their ability to make informed decisions through participation in life skills training
- **3,703 youth participants** received peer education from the youth ambassadors
- **180 AYC members received training** on gender equality, gaining knowledge on gender-based discrimination, positive masculinity, and addressing gender-based violence effectively

Life skills for informed decision making





Shanti, a young leader, strives to buid a safer community

Shanti Rani, a young leader, serves as the General Secretary of the Executive Committee of the Bamonbari Adolescents and Youth Club. She is currently studying her higher secondary at Bangabandhu Degree College in Ranisankail. In April 2021, ESDO, in collaboration with Educo Bangladesh, established the Adolescents & Youth Club with 50 members. From the beginning Shanti is an active member of this club. Through various training sessions, she has been equipped with essential life skills, knowledge on sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHR), understanding of human rights, governance, leadership skills, and public service information. This has empowered her to make informed decisions and choices in her day-to-day life.

Shanti Rani, driven by a deep sense of commitment, has consistently collaborated with her club members to undertake social initiatives such as organising humanity walls, cricket tournaments, courtyard meetings, and student home visits. Her aim is to foster empathy and unity within the community. Her altruistic mindset led her to prioritise providing safe water to all members of society.

When an organisation approached Shanti to identify community members lacking access to safe water, she saw an opportunity to make a significant difference. She discovered that 11 families were unable to afford and install tube-wells. After a thorough review by the organisation, it provided tube-wells to all 11 families, thereby ensuring access to safe drinking water for everyone in need. This intervention has had a profound impact on the lives of these families, relieving them of the burden of fetching water for others' households or long distance.

Shanti Rani, expressed,

// The community members who now have access to tube wells are delighted because they no longer need to venture out for safe drinking water, cooking, or bathing. Seeing the smiles on their faces brings me immense joy as well. //



Economic empowerment for decent work

Educo and its partner organisations adopted market-driven, gender-responsive, and community-based approaches for sustaining the economic development of adolescents and youth. We believe in the potential of the youth force to create a sustainable livelihood for themselves and their communities.

- **500 youth received career counselling**, guiding them toward potential career paths
- **2,612 individuals enhanced technical** skills through digital literacy training
- **193 participants received** market-oriented skills and business-start-up training
- **56 participants received cash support**, and **62 received in-kind assistance** to launch businesses
- **117 skilled youth entered** the workforce and involved in income generation



Brojen's skills enable him the chance to find his dream occupation

Brojen Das, a 10th-grade student from an indigenous community, faces the financial struggles that cast shadows over his daily life. Despite the daunting obstacles, he bravely shoulders the responsibility of supporting his family, often finding it challenging to attend school regularly. However, amidst these crises, Brojen harbours ambitions and does not want to be a day labourer like his parents. He yearns to acquire skills, carving a path toward a different occupation.

In the year 2021, a turning point arrived in Brojen's life when he joined the Adolescent & Youth Club (AYC). This club is formed by SACHETAN SOCIETY in collaboration with Educo Bangladesh. Here, he shared his aspiration to establish a mobile phone servicing and repair shop with the project team. Alongside 12 other individuals, he embarked on a 15-day intensive training programme, equipped with the necessary tools to realise his potential.

Initially, Brojen set up a workshop within his home. However, driven by passion, he soon expanded his horizons. Within a few days, he secured a shop in his local area. Balancing his education,



Brojen now opens his shop in the afternoons following school hours. His monthly income ranges from BDT 8,000 to 12,000. He has also ventured into the retailing of mobile phones, broadening his entrepreneurial scope.

Brojen confronted many obstacles in chasing his dream, including a lack of skills, financial constraints, and a lack of market linkages. Yet, with the support of SACHETAN SOCIETY and Educo Bangladesh, he overcame them with courage and motivation. Today, he manages his own educational expenses, provides support for his family, and serves as a mentor for other youth in his community.

Reflecting on his experiences, Brojen said:

// To achieve success, one must persevere with unstoppable determination. Stay strong against discouragement from others. //

Sports, according to Educo Bangladesh, are more than just physical activity-it empowers and motivate people. Our mission is to promote sports as a catalyst for boosting self-esteem, unlocking latent potential, and challenging harmful gender norms. Furthermore, we believe that sports promote social development and professional growth, serving as a protective tool. By integrating non-sports and sports activities, we enhance effectiveness and achieve optimal programme results.

- **20 young girls excelled** in local cricket tournaments after receiving dedicated fostering and training
- **40 talented young** athletes received comprehensive support to pursue their **dreams in various sports**
- **100 girls improved** their football performance through **specialised coaching**
- **150 girls empowered** through karate training, enhancing their self-protection skills
- **5000 AYC members participated** in a wide range of competitive sports

Sports for development





Jeba uses karate as a protection tool



Jeba joined the Adolescent & Youth Club (AYC) in 2021, where she learned about the Girls Karate Team (GKT) initiative. She was overwhelmed and later joined the team, where she received a three-month-long training in 2022. The Shariatpur Development Society runs this AYC in association with Educo Bangladesh.

Through her dedication, she learned self-defence techniques and experienced physical and mental development while also finding enjoyment. Emphasising its profound impact on her confidence and self-belief, she said;

// Karate helped me to believe in myself //

At the beginning of 2023, Jeba, and two friends from AYC took part in the National Yoga Sana competition and secured a commendable third place. This victory showed how strong she was. Feeling with confidence, she took on the role of a Karate

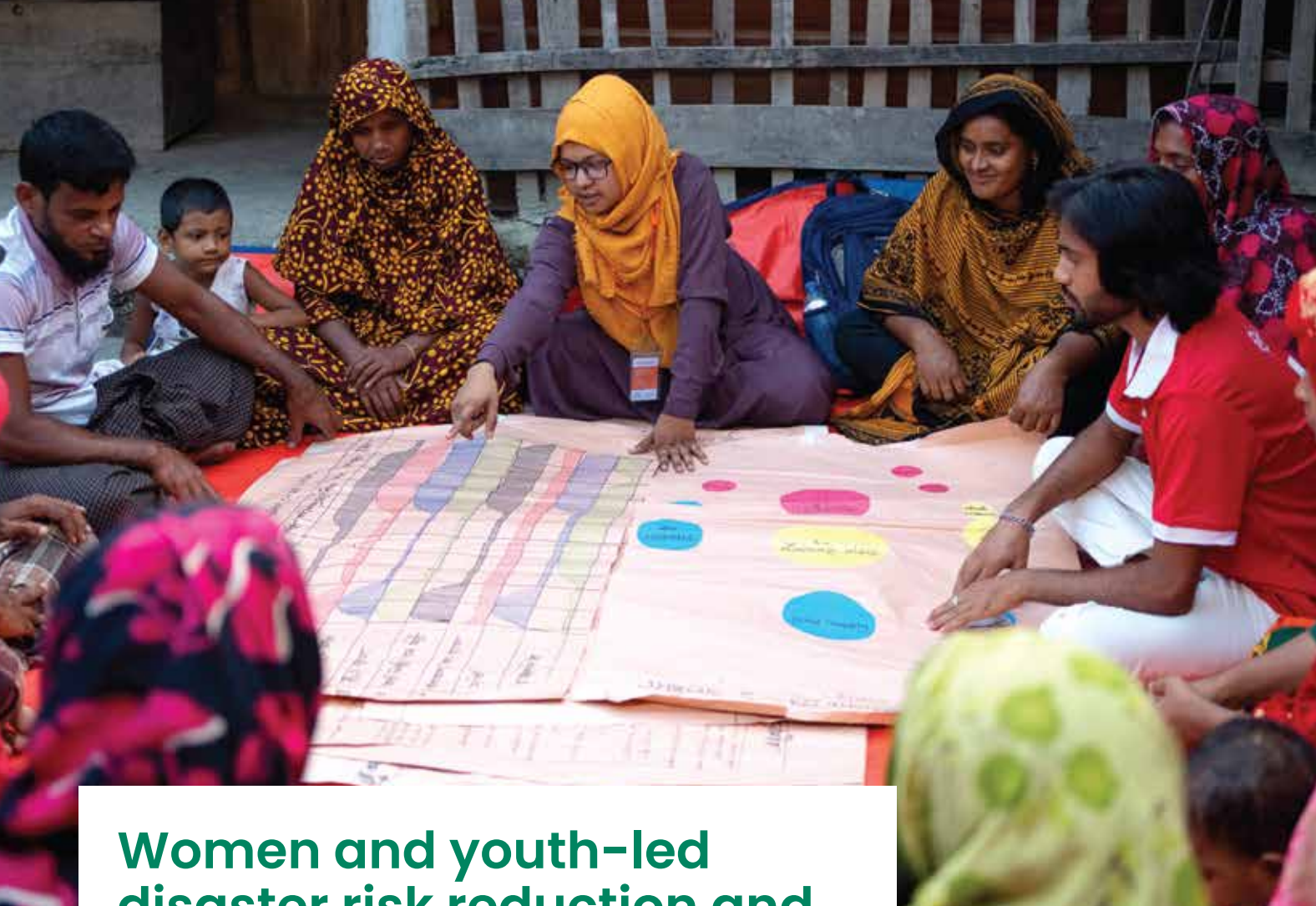
coach with a vision to empower a hundred young girls. In that year alone, she trained 60 girls, and her journey of empowerment continues. Notably, her academic performance has also seen a significant improvement.

Karate is not just a sport; it is a powerful tool for empowerment, Jeba said. Her story shows how projects that help young people feel empowered can make a big difference. Jeba's determination and strong spirit made her stand out.

As Jeba keeps going, her story inspires hope and shows others the way. It teaches us that no matter what challenges we confront, we can overcome them if we remain dedicated and persistent.

DISASTER RISK REDUCTION AND CLIMATE CHANGE ADAPTATION





Women and youth-led disaster risk reduction and climate change adaptation

The Climate Change and DRR programme is focused on enhancing communities' resilience and adaptive capacity to manage climate variability and environmental risks through the active and informed engagement of adolescents and young people. We work with adolescents and youth to enhance their knowledge and change their attitude towards improving their stewardship in climate change and DRR. Furthermore, we worked with several schools on a comprehensive school safety framework to build disaster resilience schools.

- **1,650 adolescents** and youth engaged in building environmental stewardship
- Six eco-friendly communities were established, and **362 households were involved in proper waste management**
- Enhanced awareness of **3,500 community people** on DRR and climate change to cope with the changing pattern of ecology
- Raised awareness of **2,088 community** people on internal safe migration issues
- **27 distinct climate-resilient** agriculture and non-agriculture demonstration plots have been implemented to cope with climate-adverse situations
- **2,000 adolescents and youth** are aware of disaster risk reduction and climate change



Monmohini is a successful entrepreneur who confronts all hardships



Monmohini Rani, resides in Shyamnagar, Satkhira, shows a successful example of overcoming life's adversities in challenging climatic situations by starting a successful sweet packet production business. Despite enduring the constant challenge of family hardships, she works tirelessly to support her family, engaging in activities such as fishing and labour on other people's land due to her husband's physical limitations.

In 2022, Educo Bangladesh initiated interventions in the Burigoalini Union, with the help of the EU-UNOPS LiD-funded climate displacement intervention. A Community Development Group (CDG) was formed as part of the project to prevent, protect, and respond to climate-induced displacement at the community level. Nitai Mondal, Mohini's husband, was included in the CDG as a person with disability member. The CDG discussed Monmohini Rani's family situation during their monthly meetings and explored options for alternative employment, taking into account her husband's physical condition.

After careful consideration, they decided to facilitate her training in making sweet packets. Following a five-day training period, Monmohini was advised to purchase goods worth BDT 5000 from the project, marking the start of her entrepreneurial journey.

Monmohini and her husband began making sweet packets, a well-suited profession. Their efforts have been largely successful, and the venture has significantly alleviated their financial struggles. Their monthly profit ranges between BDT 8,000-10,000. Although the project support was limited, it proved instrumental in transforming their fortunes. Today, they can afford to send their son to school and have even purchased a cow, evidence of their improved circumstances.

Monmohini Rani's voice, filled with emotion, said,

“ I have suffered greatly. No work was too low for me if it meant feeding my disabled husband, disabled children, and elderly mother-in-law. Today, I am successful and no longer in need. I have created my own business at home without working for others. I will be grateful to Educo Bangladesh for this success for the rest of my life. ”

HUMANITARIAN RESPONSE



Children
36,155



Community-based
learning centres
117



Adults
173,544



Women support
groups
10



Community
members
7,081



Community-based
child protection
committees
115



Multi-purpose
centres
9



Rohingya
volunteers
52



Adolescents and
youth clubs
106



National
teachers
62



Rohingya teachers
80



Rohingya response

Educo actively responded to 'Forcibly Displaced Myanmar Nationals' (FDMN), focusing on child protection, gender-based violence, and discrimination. In humanitarian response, Educo facilitated education support, child protection, DRR and climate adaptation, and livelihood programmes, fostering partnerships and localisation with sustainability.

- **1,500 Rohingya children** had access Education in Emergency
- **18,80 accessed life skills**, with **1,200 utilised the knowledge** for social change in camps and host community



Breaking menstrual taboos, Habiba is now a regular student

Breaking menstrual taboos, Habiba is Now a Regular Student

Umme Habiba, a 14-year-old adolescent girl residing in a camp under the Ukhiya sub-district in Cox's Bazar, found herself confined by societal taboos and parental restrictions. Despite her potential, she was denied access to schooling due to cultural norms dictating that girls refrain from attending classes once they begin menstruating.

However, Habiba's narrative took a positive turn when she came across Educo's Community-Based Learning Facilities (CBLF) initiative. Through this initiative, she gained access to education and a platform to challenge prevailing norms. Initially hindered by her mother's restrictions, Habiba's attendance further declined as she struggled with the onset of her menstrual cycle.

Recognising the situation's urgency, Educo's teachers spoke with Habiba's mother. They started to change her opinion through constant discussions about social taboos regarding menstruation and the importance of menstrual hygiene.

With persistent efforts and empathy, they convinced Habiba's mother to reconsider, ultimately enabling Habiba to continue her education.

Eventually, Habiba emerged as a change agent within her community. Equipped with an understanding of gender equality and human rights, she set out to educate her friends about the value of education and menstrual hygiene.

She said,

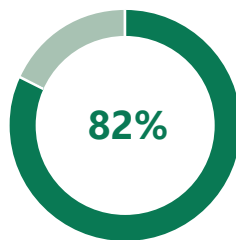
// I dream of finishing my education and fighting to improve the lives of the people in my community, especially the girls //

SPONSORSHIP PROGRAMME

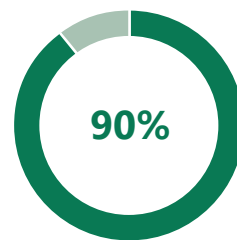
Sponsorship programme have made significant strides in placing a strong emphasis on enhancing the well-being and development of children within communities. Sponsorship programme is an individual funding system and the programme's core objectives are providing children with access to education, ensuring their protection, and fostering their development.



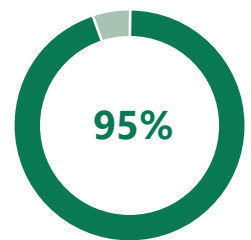
Access to the quality education



Reduction of drop-outs from schools



Ensured participation and benefited in development projects



Participated in adolescent and youth clubs and community-based child protection



Sponsorship creates a bridge between sponsors and sponsored children

The sponsorship programme creates a bridge of friendship between donors from abroad and sponsored children in communities. Development projects are implemented from individual donors' contributions for not only sponsored children but also for all the children around them.

Sponsorship creates loyalty towards sponsors

With continued support from sponsors, our commitment remained to collect loyalty elements for sponsors from time to time, like children's photographs, artworks, case stories, testimonies, and many more, to provide updates on the children's progress. Most importantly, these elements are token gifts to sponsors and are intended to create a long-lasting relationship between sponsored children and sponsors.

Sponsorship implementation and accountability towards children



Jeba joined the Adolescent & Youth Club (AYC) in 2021, where she learned about the Girls Karate Team (GKT) initiative. She was overwhelmed and later joined the team, where she received a three-month-long training in 2022. The Shariatpur Development Society runs this AYC in association with Educo Bangladesh.

Through her dedication, she learned self-defence techniques and experienced physical and mental development while also finding enjoyment. Emphasising its profound impact on her confidence and self-belief, she said;



ADVOCACY FOR SOCIAL CHANGE

Educo's primary and overarching advocacy goals revolve around establishing and upholding children's rights. Our active participation is evident in our membership within numerous global and national alliances and networks. Our constructive relationships extend to key governmental bodies, such as the Parliamentary Caucus on Child Rights, the Ministry of Labour and Employment, and the Ministry of Women and Children Affairs. We also play an integral role as members of diverse child rights-focused committees under these ministries, collaboratively observing national and international occasions under their leadership. Emphasising the crucial need for collaborating efforts to eliminate child labour with like-minded organisations, Educo leads to establishing a new platform called the Child Labour Elimination Platform (CLEP) to eliminate child labour in Bangladesh with robust joint advocacy.

In 2023, Educo Bangladesh's key joint advocacies were submitting the Universal Periodic Review (UPR) report to the UN Committee and the Girl Child Situation Report in Bangladesh 2021-2022, Bangladesh's first-ever report.

On National Girl Child Day, 30 September, a Special Supplement was published jointly with the Ministry of Women and Children Affairs (MoWCA) in three National Dailies. It contained messages from the highest-level Policy Makers of the State along with the Country Director of Educo Bangladesh.

Joint Consultation and Dialogues with the National Human Rights Commission Bangladesh to enact the Comprehensive Sexual Harassment Prevention & Remedy Law. As a result, a five-member committee was formed under the leadership of NHRC to shape the full-fledged law and initiative for submission to the Ministry of Law and Parliamentary Justice.

INNOVATION

The innovation programme involves creatively addressing social challenges fostering the programme's impact and sustainability.

Youth-led community-based child protection systems

Educo, a child rights-based organisation, promotes the functioning of the child protection system. As an innovative initiative, Educo focuses on a youth-led, community-based child protection system, where a group of youths, with the support of community leaders, act to protect children from all forms of violence, exploitation, abuse, and neglect. It is innovative as youths lead here and cover the village level where youths can act comfortably. Besides, it includes representatives from a wide range of community clusters. Additionally, it establishes a linkage with Union and Upazila-level violence prevention committees align with government policies and systems.

Community-led child labour monitoring committee (CLCLMC)

The community-led child labour monitoring committee (CLCLMC) is an innovative strategic mechanism to eliminate child labour through mobilising the community. Educo's child labour projects emphasise strengthening community participation in functioning CLCLMC and creating ownership in the community that contributes to achieving the project goal to eliminate hazardous child labour. In Bangladesh, no similar community-based committee exists specifically for monitoring child labour situations.

The CLCLMC plays a crucial role not only in monitoring child labour but also in motivating parents to withdraw their children from work and continue their education. They actively sensitize duty bearers and employers and follow up on local efforts to eliminate child labour. By motivating parents, children, employers, and the community, the CLCLMC helps ensure that working children can continue their education and understand the negative impacts of child labour.

Thus, the CLCLMC represents a unique programmatic strategy in Educo's Child Labour project in Bangladesh. Under this project, the CLCLMC works closely to monitor child labour situation at the local level and motivate employers and community people, serving as an influential and supportive group.

Innovative approach and methodology to improve the reading writing skills

The Reading and Writing Hospital is an innovative approach introducing play-based materials to address learning deficits and improve elementary school students' reading and writing skills, a promising path to quality education. Tailored for slow learners, it bridges educational gaps and fosters overall child development. The collaboration between the ALOY ALOW Project and the Upazila Education Office to develop the materials, conduct training for primary school teachers and distribute materials with greater acknowledgement by the Upazila administration. The method has been highly appreciated and accepted by the upazila and district administration and introduced this method to different Govt primary schools in Moulvibazar.

Playground for children's physical development in early childhood development

Children of the Tea Labour community are far away from the play facilities at schools and home. Lack of awareness and extreme poverty behind to get play items in their childhood. Educo established permanent structures of 50 ECD centres equipped with playgrounds, which creates a safe and friendly

play opportunity for underserved children. This opportunity accelerated the children's physical and psychological development and created a better environment to improve the learning outcomes.

Eco-friendly communities for environmental sustainability

The concept of Eco-Friendly Communities is a novel innovation in Bangladesh. Educo is supporting the promotion of six model communities that prioritise eco-friendly practices. Eco-friendly is defined as actions or practices that are not harmful to the environment or actively try to help the environment. Youth are the key to the model. The innovation strategically implemented in Shariatpur and Barguna districts in Bangladesh, these model communities spearhead the response to climate-related challenges through youth-led strategies. Empowering youth with knowledge, skills, and eco-friendly facilities. Communities tackle climate change with 7 standards in the eco-village model, promoting disaster risk reduction, environmental safeguards, reduced plastic use, composting, zero waste, and green energy adoption. Seven standards are:



BEST PRACTICES

Promoting empowerment for girls through sports

A primary emphasis of our initiatives is the empowerment of adolescent girls, achieved through proficiency in sports and self-defence techniques. In light of the escalating instances of challenges like sexual harassment, child marriage, and violence against women in our country, encouraging participation in diverse events becomes pivotal in cultivating awareness among these young individuals. By actively involving them in pursuits such as karate, cricket, football, and dance teams, these adolescents develop valuable skills and gain the ability to navigate societal challenges, steering clear of the disparities prevalent in our community. This approach is a best practice in fostering empowerment and resilience among young girls.

Youth-led climate change

We are dedicated to empowering children and youth with the knowledge and tools necessary to address the challenges posed by climate change. Our strategy involves conducting actionable social research to pinpoint solutions for communities affected by climate issues. In Shariatpur and Barguna, we've launched youth-led climate change projects, forming and training six groups of 30 members each. These groups actively raise awareness about climate change impacts and advocate for innovative adaptation technologies in sustainable agriculture. In alignment with our vision, we're establishing six eco-model communities as exemplars of ecological transition, showcasing alternative solutions for climate change adaptation. Through these efforts, we aim to empower youth and communities to actively participate in climate change adaptation, promoting resilience and sustainable practices.

IMPLEMENTING PARTNERS



STRATEGIC PARTNERS

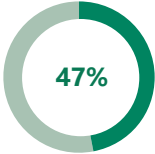


DEVELOPMENT PARTNERS

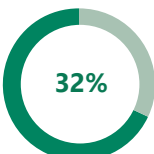
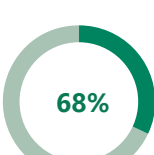


FINANCIALS

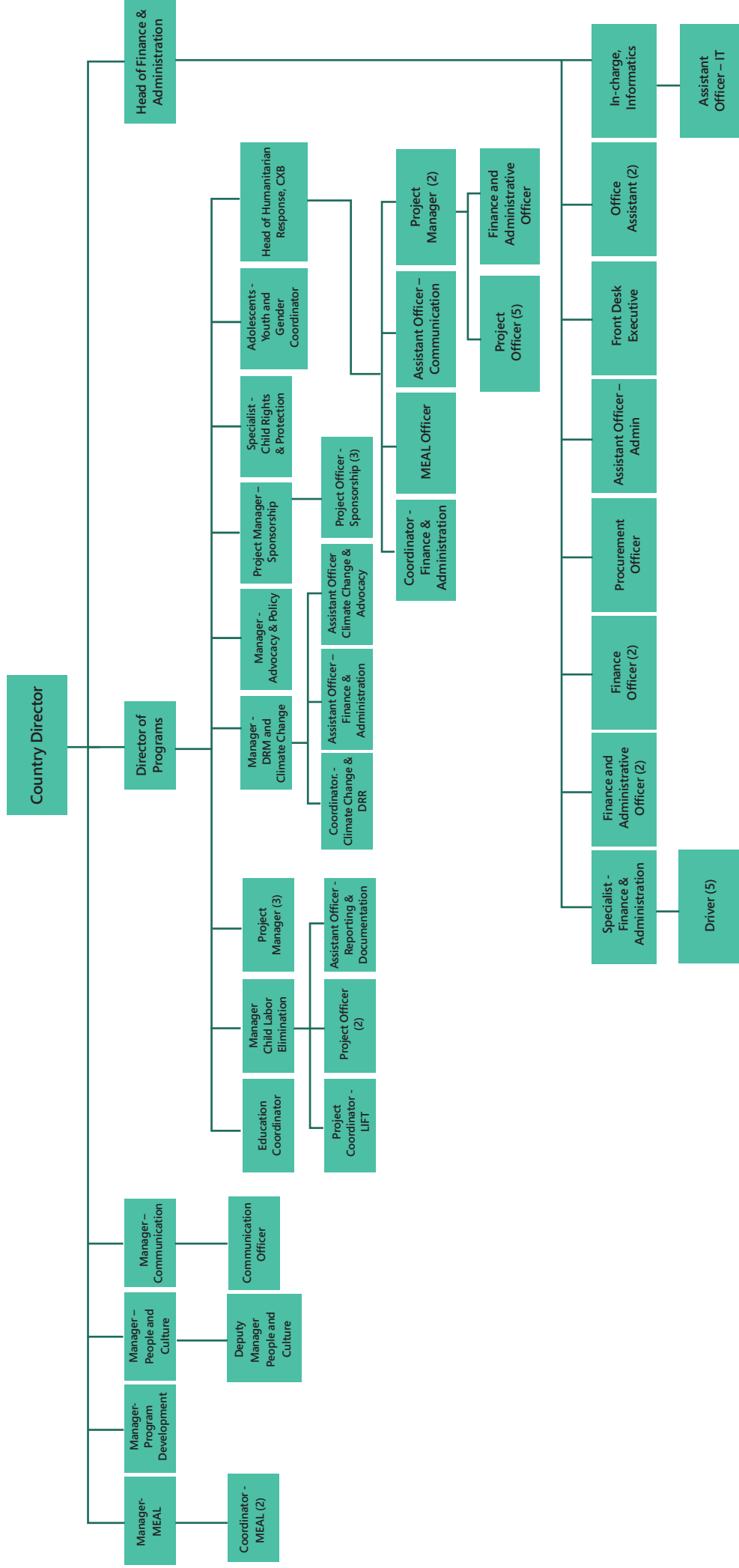
Budget -2023

Total:	€	3,272,970	 100%
Private fund:	€	1,533,146	 47%
External fund:	€	1,739,824	 53%

Execution-2023

Total:	€	3,191,142	 97.5%
Private fund:	€	1,028,451	 32%
External fund including co- financing	€	2,162,691	 68%

Educo Bangladesh Organogram





Education and Development Foundation-Educo
House-30 CWN (A), Level-3, Road-42/43
Gulshan-2, Dhaka-1212
Bangladesh

